Off the Hook?

Disasters and Public Opinion in Authoritarian Russia

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When disaster strikes under autocracy

- Many autocracies lean on **performance** to legitimate themselves (Gerschewski 2013)
- Disasters are tests of that performance
- The Winter Cherry shopping-centre fire, Kemerovo, 2018
- Fires in psychiatric hospitals
- Floods and forest fires
- So when disaster strikes, does the public hold the regime **to account**?



Winter Cherry, Kemerovo, 25 March 2018. Photo: Russian Emergencies Ministry (mchs.gov.ru), CC BY 4.0, via Wikimedia Commons.

What we know and what we don't

- Democracies: voters **punish** poor performance (Healy & Malhotra 2009; Gasper & Reeves 2011), even for acts of nature (Achen & Bartels 2016)
- Autocracies: blame attribution (Beazer & Reuter 2019), affective bonds (Greene & Robertson 2019; Frye 2021)
- Lazarev et al. (2014): 2010 wildfires **raised** support, a *rally*
- The record is **contradictory**
- No multi-event, individual-level test of disaster accountability in an autocracy

Research question

- Does a disaster in one's region shift support for the regime (**Putin**) or its local agent (the **governor**)?

Russia, briefly

- Electoral autocracy; media largely state-controlled
- **Putin's approval** is the regime's currency, polled constantly
- **Governors** run the regions, hired and fired by the Kremlin
  - a convenient place to send blame: "good tsar, bad boyars"

Would anyone blame Putin?

- Scholars expect it: disasters "handled poorly, often spark popular outrage and threaten an autocrat's hold on power" (Goldring et al. 2025)
- Russians sometimes aim at the top
  - 2010 wildfires, to Putin's face: "We asked for help. We trusted you."
  - Orsk floods, 2024: crowds chanting "Putin, help us!"
- The Kremlin acts as if blame could reach him: televised dressing-downs of officials; governors as "scapegoats or whipping boys" (Klimovich 2024)
- Although after the 2010 fires, only **3%** named Putin (then prime minister) among officials to fire; governors 15%, fire chiefs 24% (Levada, via Giuliano 2013)

Expectations

- **Accountability:** a regime that claims to deliver is judged on delivery; approval **falls**
- **Insulation or rally:** state media, blame pushed down, ideology over performance

Pre-registered:

- **H1** Disasters reduce approval, more so for severe disasters
- **H2** Larger effects on the governor (specific support) than on Putin (diffuse support)

What I find

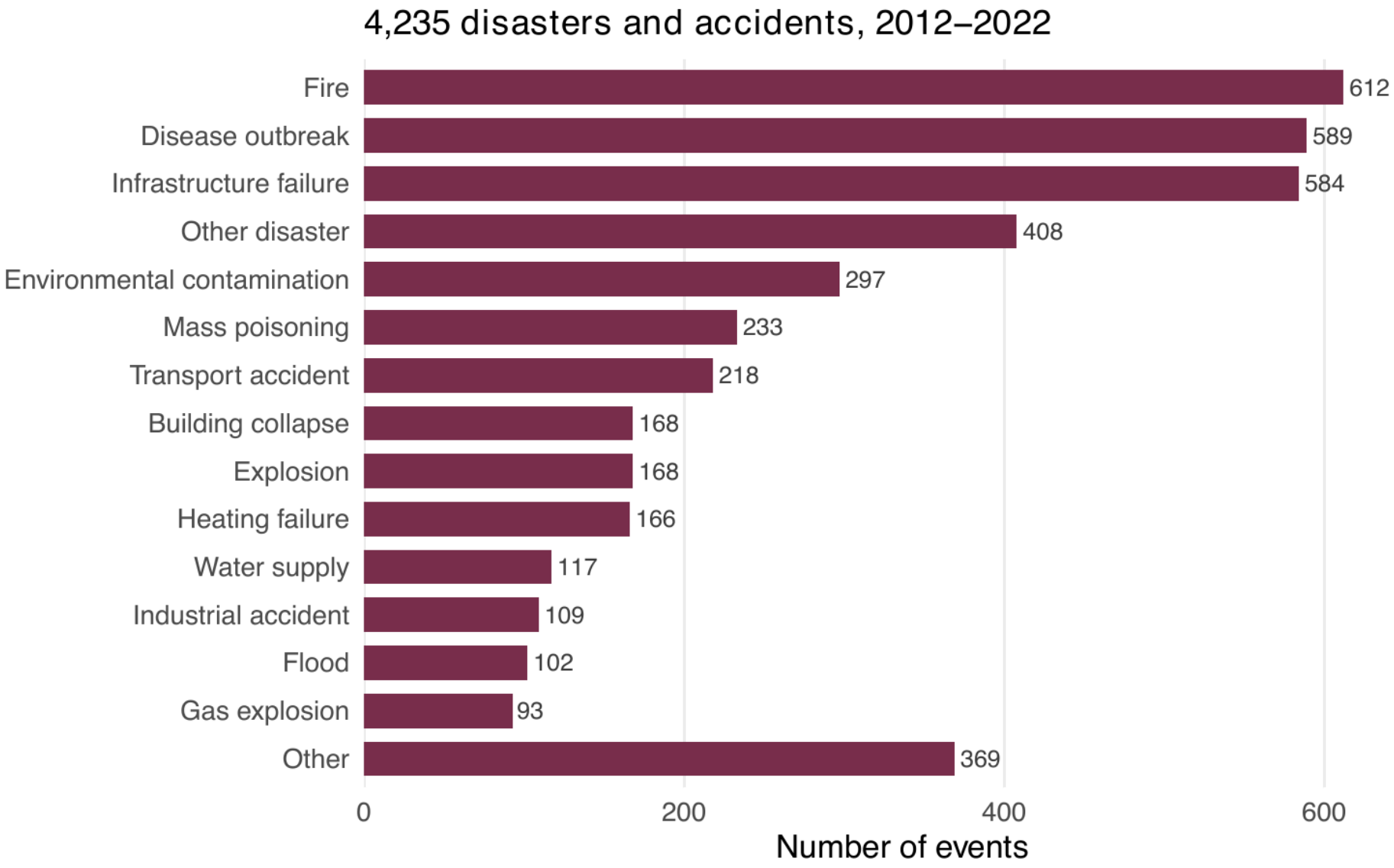
- On average, Putin's approval **does not** move: any effect is under half a percentage point
  - the exception: the disasters people talk about online
- Naive "rally" estimates are there **before** the disaster happens
- If anyone is blamed, it is the **governor**: hints, not yet findings

Regime approval is insulated from local disasters, however hard I look

Data and design

Disaster data

- **4,235** disasters and accidents, 2012–2022, 83 regions
- Built from FPP regional news digests: **≈95,000** raw events
  - keyword rules + a large language model (Claude) flag disasters
  - the model codes type, deaths, severity, preventability
  - Hand-code samples to verify
- Deliberately **broad**: fires, floods, industrial, transport, gas explosions, poisonings, infrastructure failures
- About a third look like non-disasters (animal die-offs, court cases, announcements): keeping or dropping them gives the same null



Source: FPP regional digests, 2012–2022.

When exactly?

- The digests give only the **month**; a 30-day window needs the **day**
- **2,713** events dated to the day:
  - a language model reads news reports for the stated date (1,777)
  - the day social media lit up (701)
  - official records: EM-DAT, Investigative Committee (235)
- A blind re-check by another model agrees within a day on **94%** of its confident answers

And a lot of other data

In the results today

- EM-DAT, an international disaster database
- Emergency ministry statistics
- Regional Telegram and VK channels: how much a disaster is discussed
- “What events do you remember from the past week?”

Checking the event data

- Wikipedia and Wikidata
- Regional newspapers
- Weather-hazard and air-crash registers: what the digests miss
- Yandex search volume

In progress

- Government response: emergency decrees, federal reserve funds, Kremlin and regional-government news, officials fired

Survey data

- Pooled, harmonized Russian polls: Levada, VTsIOM, FOM
  - **5.4 million** responses; **2.6 million** (Putin) and **1.2 million** (governor) in the disaster years
  - interview date and region for every respondent
  - including VTsIOM daily phone survey, ≈1,600 interviews a day
- Outcomes (yes / no):
  1. Approval of **Putin**: diffuse, regime-level support
  2. Approval of the **governor**: specific, local support

Estimation

Individual-level difference-in-differences

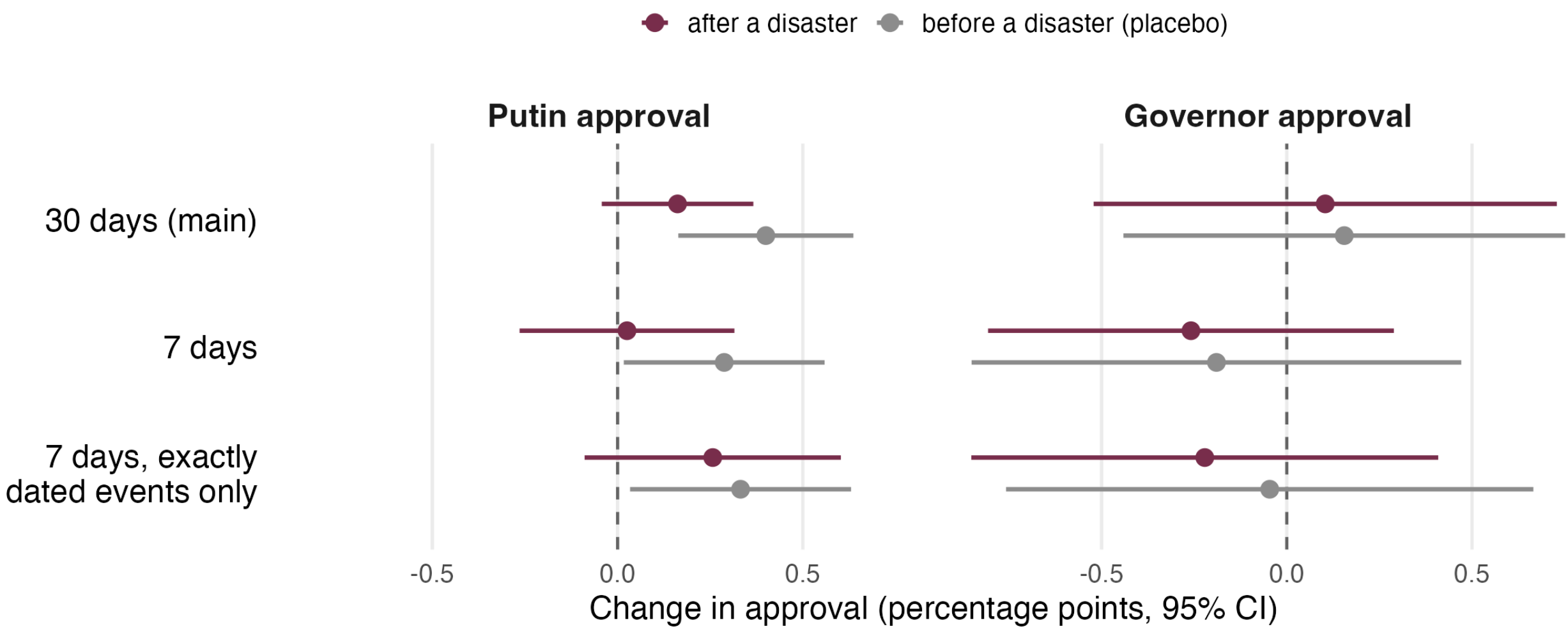
- Did approval in your region change in the **30 days after** a disaster, compared with your region at other times and other regions that month?
- OLS with region, month, survey fixed effects; SEs clustered by region
- Polls are not representative *within* regions, but each region is compared with itself

Key check: a pre-event placebo

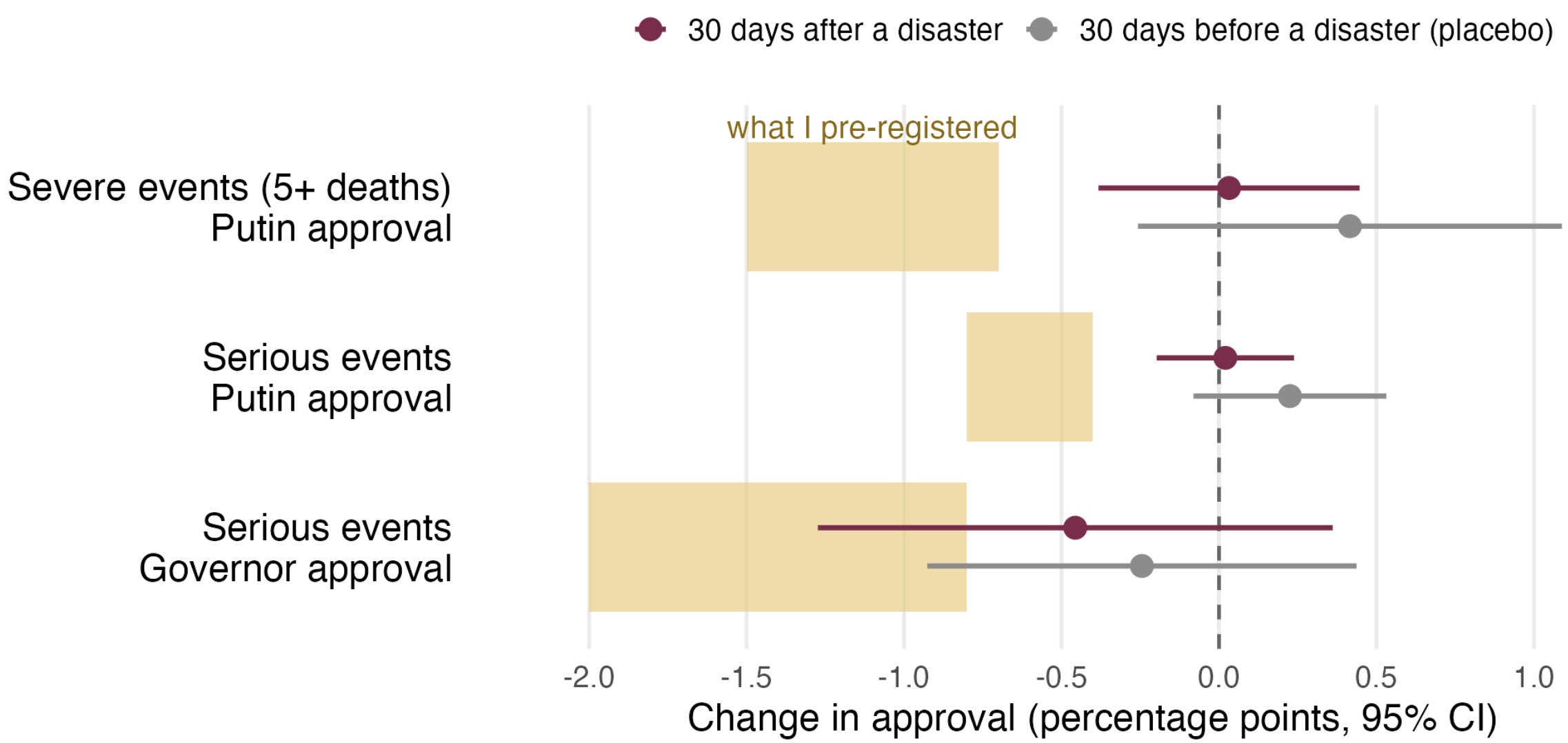
A disaster that has not happened yet cannot move approval today

- So I also estimate the “effect” of a disaster in the **next** 30 days
- If a future disaster “predicts” approval as well as a past one, the estimate may reflect **which region-months get disasters recorded**

Results



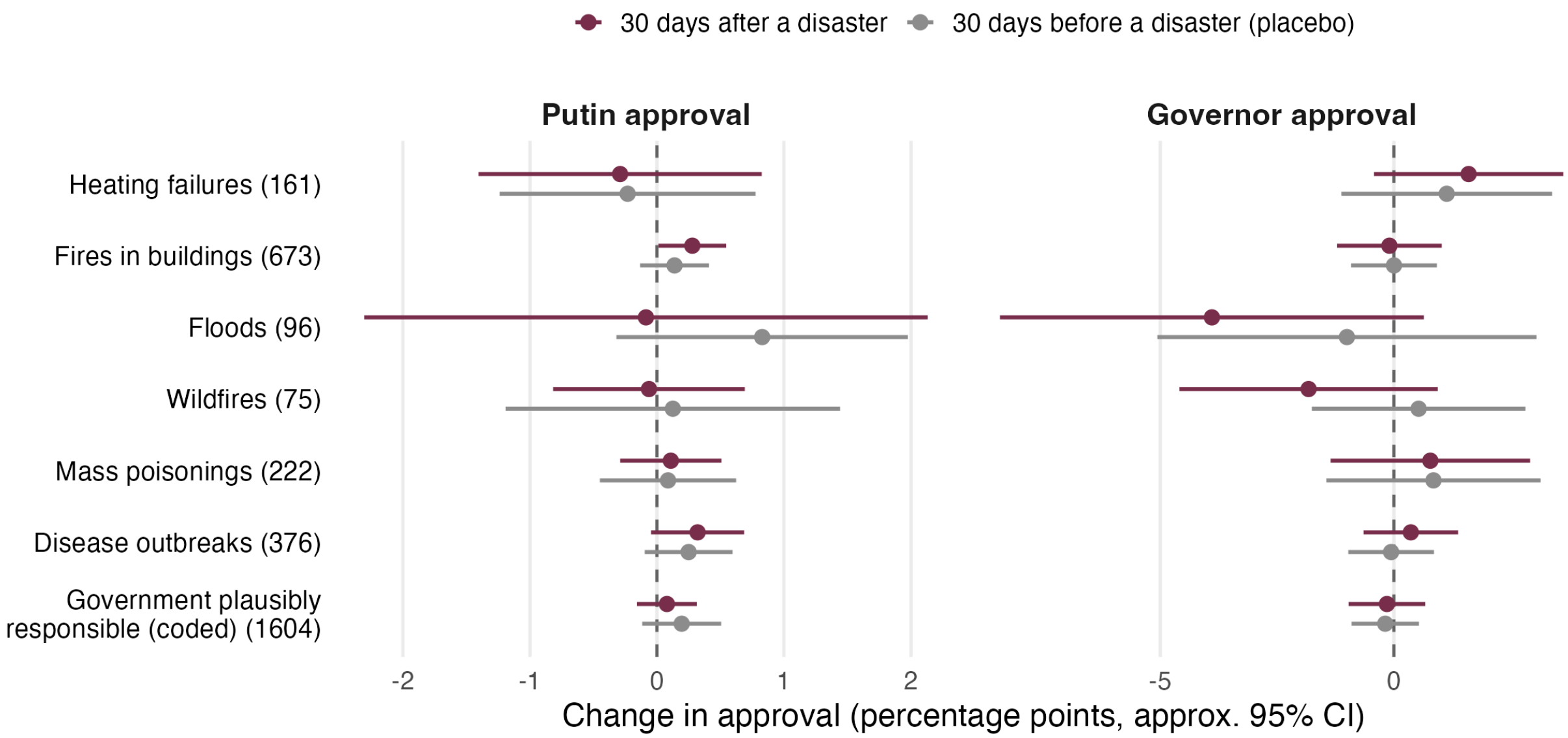
- Putin: +0.2 points after a disaster (not distinguishable from zero), **+0.4 before** one
- Governor: nothing either way


30 days after a disaster
30 days before a disaster (placebo)
what I pre-registered
Severe events (5+ deaths)
Putin approval
Serious events
Putin approval
Serious events
Governor approval
-2.0
-1.5
-1.0
-0.5
0.0
0.5
1.0
Change in approval (percentage points, 95% CI)

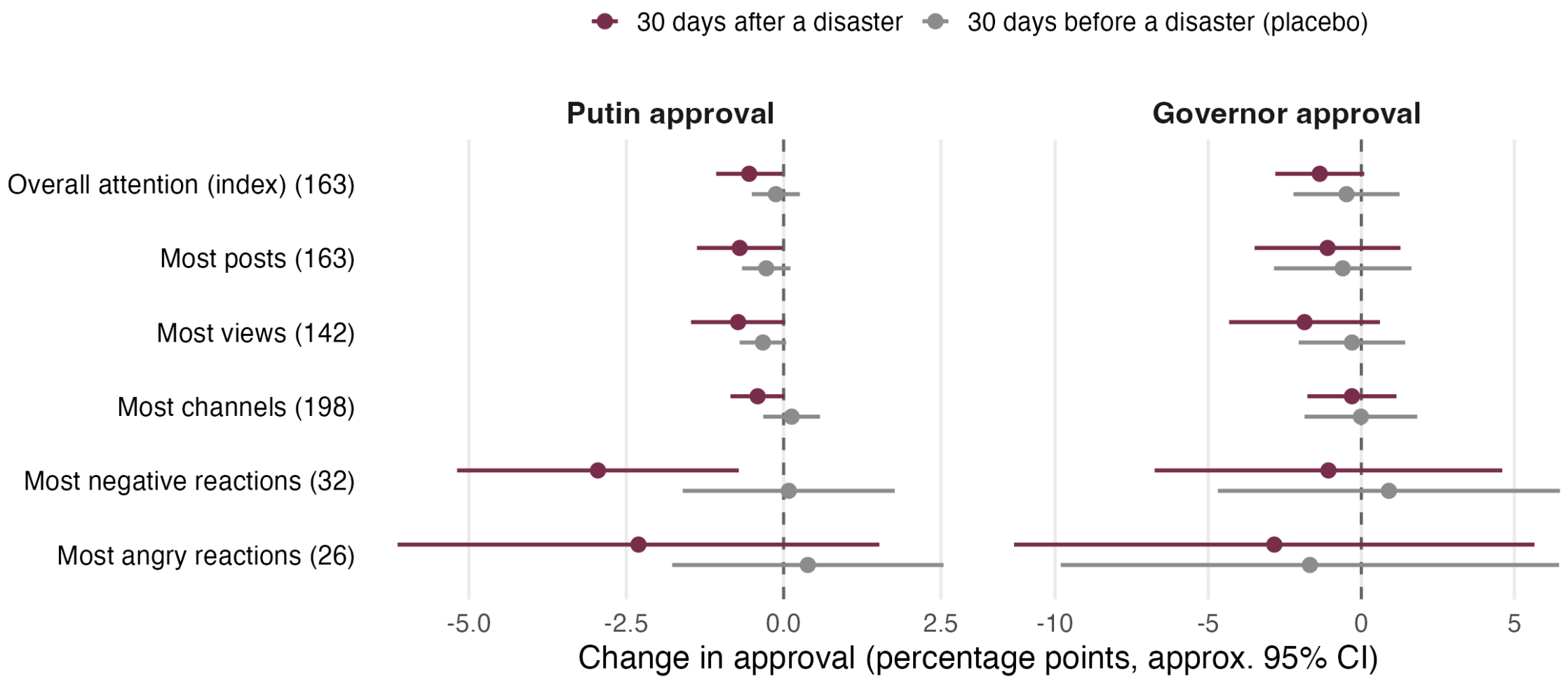
Checking the nulls

- Windows of 7, 14, 30, 60 days
- Stricter comparisons: within region-year, region trends, seasons
- Only severe, only serious, only events confirmed by 3+ independent sources
- Independent disaster records: EM-DAT, emergency ministry
- Phone vs. face-to-face surveys; pre- vs. post-2014; few-cluster inference
- The daily phone survey, day by day
- Other regional news as a placebo: ceremonial news shows the same “before” bump
- Moderators: salience, novelty, type, respondent characteristics
- Region by region: for Putin, no more significant regions than chance

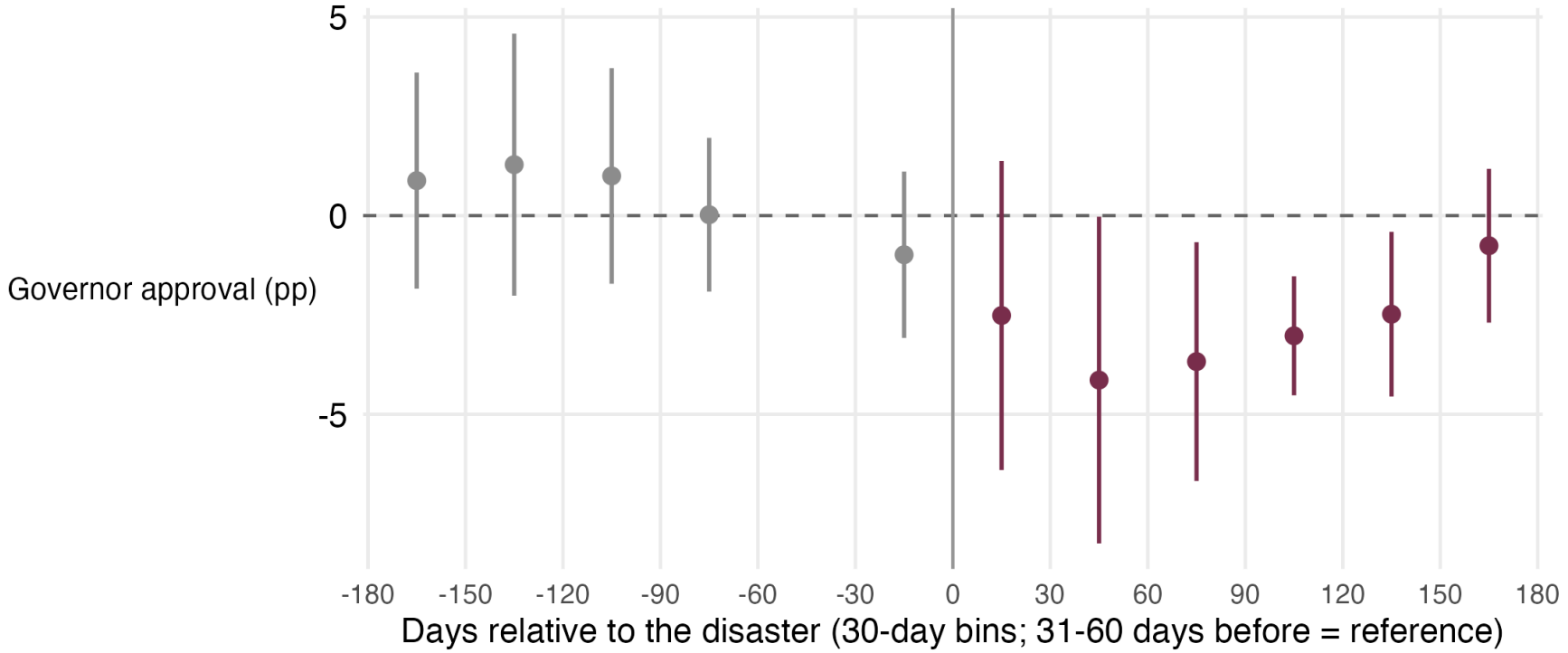
No significant drop in Putin’s approval bigger than half a point. The exception: disasters people talk about.



- Even disasters the state is plainly on the hook for show no detectable drop



- Top quarter by attention in regional Telegram and VK channels, 2018–22
- After: Putin about **–0.5 to –0.7** points (p ≈ .05); governor mostly **–1 to –2**, but noisier and not significant; before: nothing



- **Big disasters** (EM-DAT: 10+ dead, 100+ affected, or an emergency declared)
  - comparing within region-year: governor approval **2.5–4 points lower**, one to five months later; flat before
- **Most-discussed** disasters online: governor **–1.4** (30 days), **–2.0** (14 days)
- But: a handful of big episodes carry it, and in the main model it is weaker. **Hints, not findings**

Why no accountability for Putin?

- Tentative reading: the **blame channel is severed**
  - state control of the information environment
  - legitimation through ideology, not performance
  - blame steered down to governors
- And most people never hear about a given disaster
  - “what do you remember from the past week?”: even after a 20+ death disaster, only about 1 in 5 locals name it

Can we test these?

- **Information control** → compare internet users with non-users; regions with freer media
  - internet users: also nothing
- **Ideology, not performance** → before vs. after 2014
  - before 2014, a ~2-point *rally*; after, no clear effect
- **Nobody hears about it** → who remembers which disaster
  - typical disaster: no rise in people naming one

Work in progress: did the state respond?

- Maybe the average hides **rallies** when the state responds and **punishment** when it doesn't
- Trying to build this:
  - **emergency declared? money paid?** regional decrees; federal reserve-fund orders (382, 2012–2023)
  - **did leaders show up?** Kremlin website; archived regional-government news (62 regions)
  - **was anyone punished?** officials fired or prosecuted afterwards, from news reports
  - **did people notice the response?** "what do you remember" answers
- Status: built from archives and records; **not yet checked** against hand-coding

Conclusions

- No measurable accountability in Putin's approval, 2012–2022: under half a point, severe events included
  - the exception worth chasing: disasters people talk about
- Naive estimates often mislead: the "rally" is there before the disaster
- Blame, if any, lands on **governors**...maybe

Next

- Who actually knew?
- Did the state respond? (feasible?)
- Daily surveys and exactly-dated hazards

Thank you!

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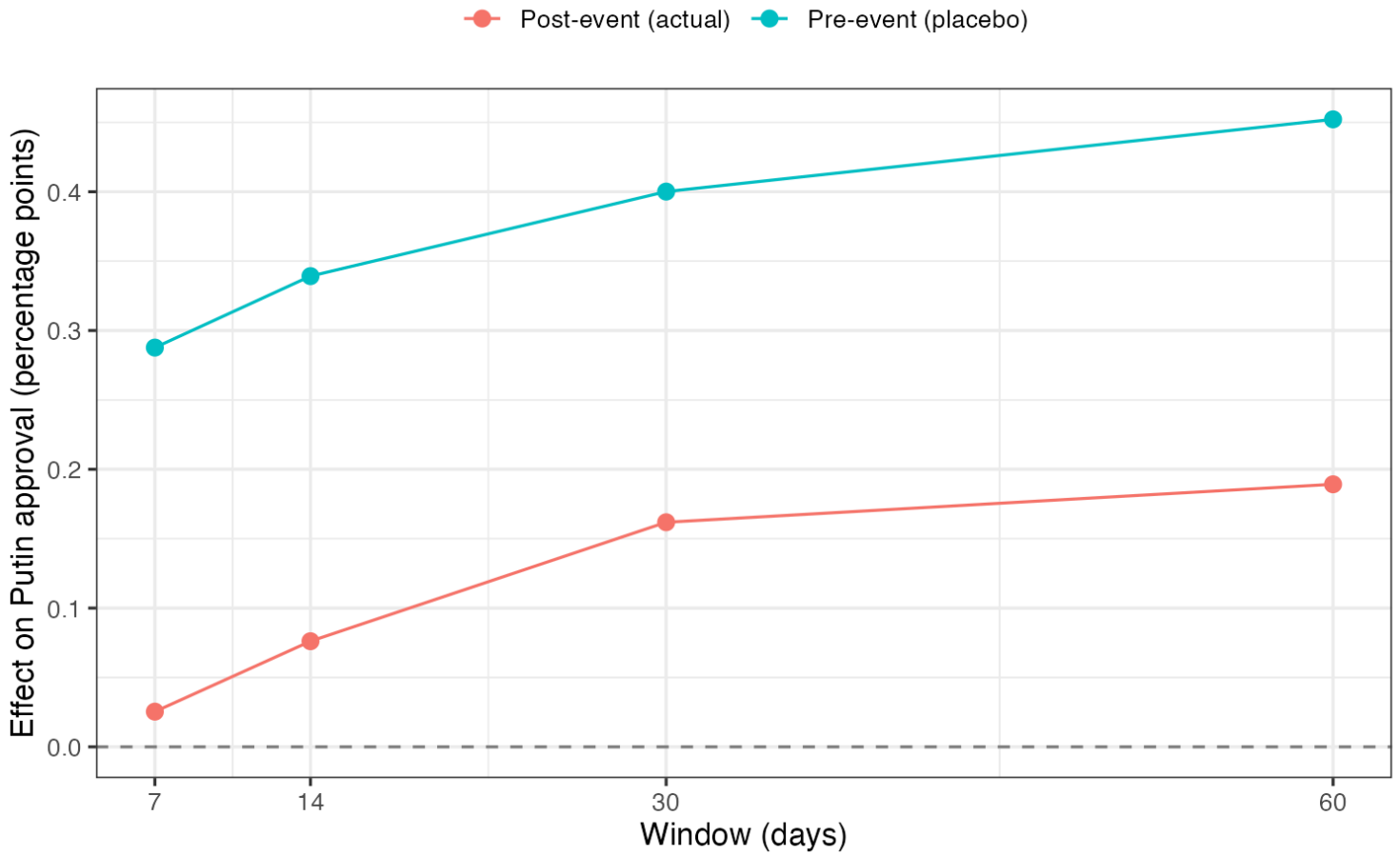
Backup

Main result as a table

	Putin: after	Putin: before (placebo)	Governor: after	Governor: before (placebo)
Disaster in region, 30 days	0.002	0.004**	0.001	0.002
	(0.001)	(0.001)	(0.003)	(0.003)
Region / month / survey fixed effects	✓	✓	✓	✓
Interviews (83 regions)	2,601,990	2,601,990	1,240,834	1,240,834

*Outcome: approval (0/1). Standard errors clustered by region. ** p < .01.*

- After minus before, in one model: −0.23 points (p = .02). Wild-cluster bootstrap p for “after” = .17



Putin approval, percentage points.

How the estimate moves with the comparison

comparison (Putin, 30 days)	after	before (placebo)	after – before
region + month (main)	+0.17 (0.10)	+0.40 (0.12)**	−0.23 (0.10)*
within region-year	−0.02 (0.08)	+0.15 (0.08)*	−0.18 (0.10)$^{+}$
region-specific trends (pre-registered)	−0.00 (0.08)	+0.24 (0.08)**	−0.24 (0.10)*
region × calendar month	+0.24 (0.14)$^{+}$	+0.49 (0.14)**	−0.25 (0.10)*

- "After": −0.2 to +0.5 points across all four (95% CIs). Net of the "before" bump: about −0.2, CIs reaching −0.45
- Governor: every "after" within ±0.2 of zero, SEs 0.25–0.34

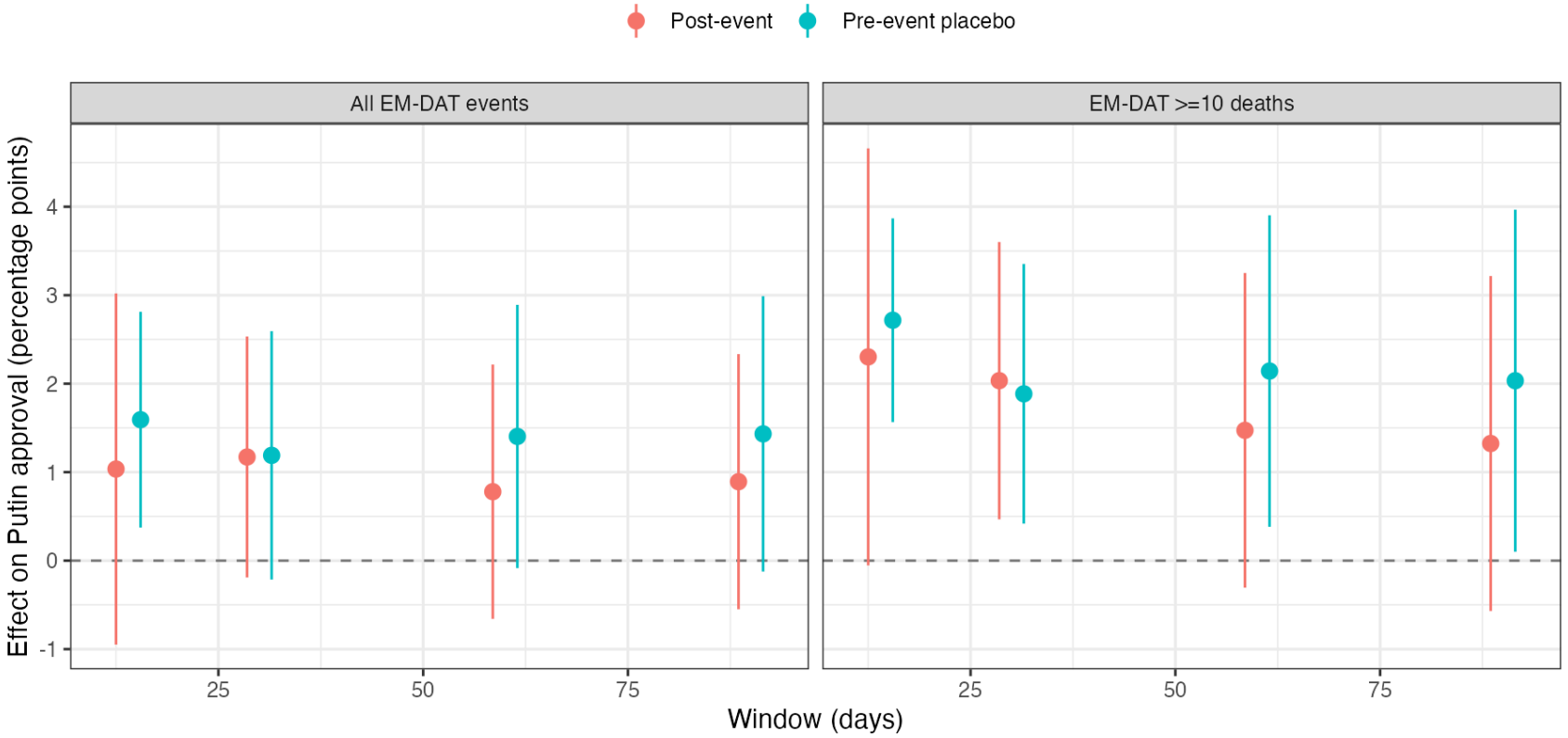
The “rally” lives in the least serious, least confirmed events

event tier (Putin, 30 days)	events	after	before (placebo)
low severity	1,706	**+0.34** (0.16)	**+0.64** (0.13)
medium severity	1,393	+0.08 (0.13)	+0.20 (0.19)
high severity	432	−0.10 (0.18)	+0.09 (0.26)
no independent trace	602	+0.66 (0.35)	**+0.85** (0.30)
confirmed by ≥ 3 independent sources	612	−0.01 (0.17)	−0.05 (0.16)

Percentage points. Each family’s tiers in one model with after and before indicators.

- An inverse dose-response looks like a recording artefact; the pre-registration also allowed a small low-severity rally

Independent disaster records



- **EM-DAT**: Putin estimates move with their own placebo (≥ 10 deaths: +2.0 vs. +1.9 points); one governor cell does not (wildfires, –13.6 points), and it is one 2019 episode
- **Emergency ministry** (region-year counts): –0.02 points per emergency (p = .80)

What I pre-registered, in numbers

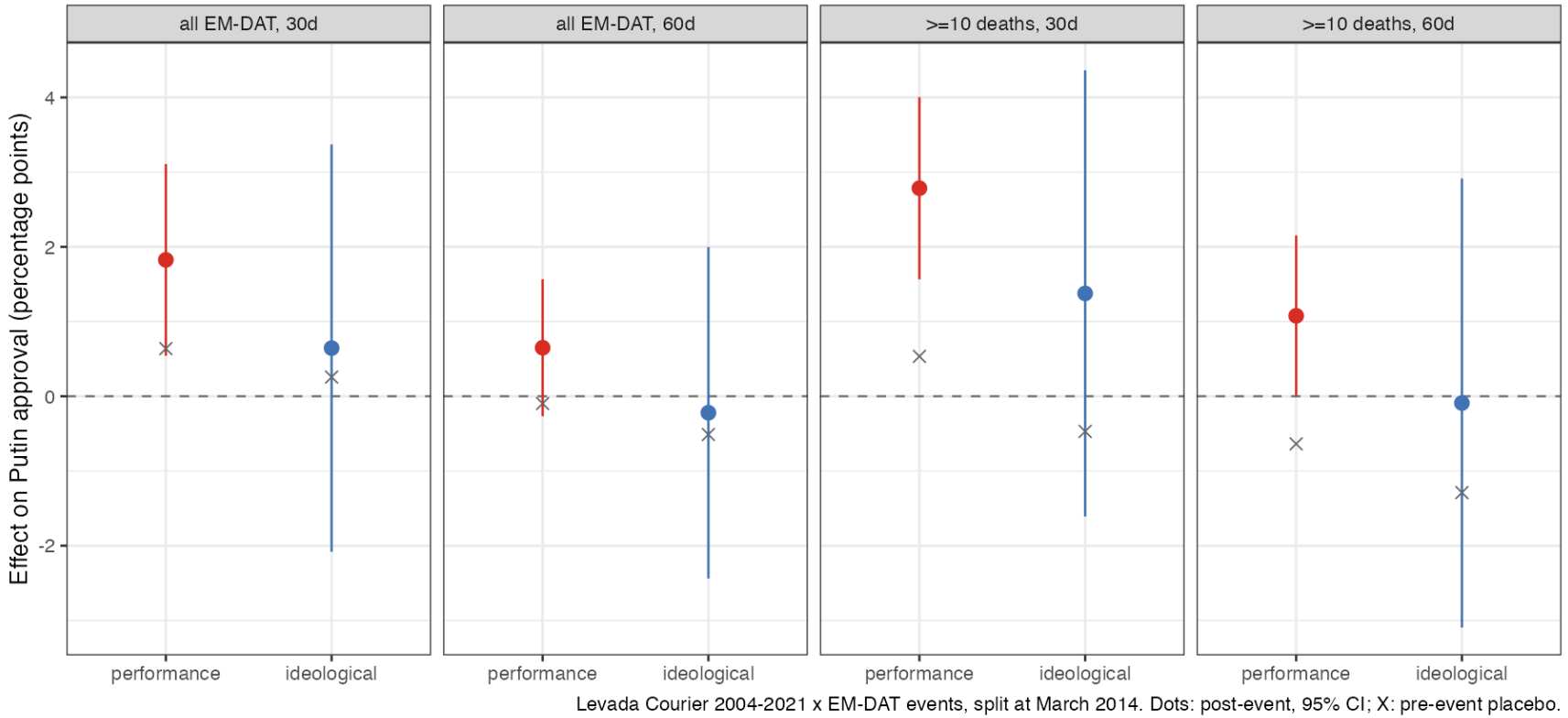
tier, 30 days (outcome)	expected, May 2026	after	before (placebo)	detectable effect
all events, 4,152 (Putin)	≈ 0	+0.16 (0.10)	+0.40 (0.12)**	0.29
serious, 1,127 (Putin)	−0.4 to −0.8	+0.02 (0.11)	+0.22 (0.16)	0.31
serious, 1,127 (governor)	−0.8 to −2.0	−0.46 (0.42)	−0.24 (0.35)	1.17
validated, 802 (Putin)	−0.5 to −1.0	+0.11 (0.36)	+0.20 (0.31)	1.00
≥ 5 deaths, 165 (Putin)	−0.7 to −1.5	+0.03 (0.21)	+0.42 (0.34)	0.59
≥ 5 deaths (governor)	none registered	−0.88 (0.87)	−1.15 (1.24)	2.4

Percentage points; SEs in parentheses; detectable effect = 2.8 × SE (80% power). Events with a region (4,152 of 4,235). ≥ 5 deaths rows: that tier estimated jointly with its placebo.

How many people know?

share of the region aware	Putin, all events	Putin, ≥ 5 deaths	governor, all events	governor, ≥ 5 deaths
100%	0.3	0.6	0.9	2.2
50%	0.6	1.2	1.8	4.5
20%	1.5	3.0	4.5	11
10%	2.9	5.9	8.9	22

Smallest effect among the aware the design would detect, percentage points. The ≥ 5-death columns come from a single severity-window indicator with no placebo term, hence governor 2.2 here vs 2.4 in the pre-registration table. Open recall of a specific event: 0.1% of respondent-event pairs nationally (≥ 20 deaths: 4% nationally, about 18% in the region); search volume rises about 9% in the event week.



Putin approval, percentage points. Levada 2004–2021 × EM-DAT events, split at March 2014. Dots: after, 95% CI; X: before (placebo). Same survey (Levada Courier) and event source in both periods.

Daily phone survey and a stricter comparison

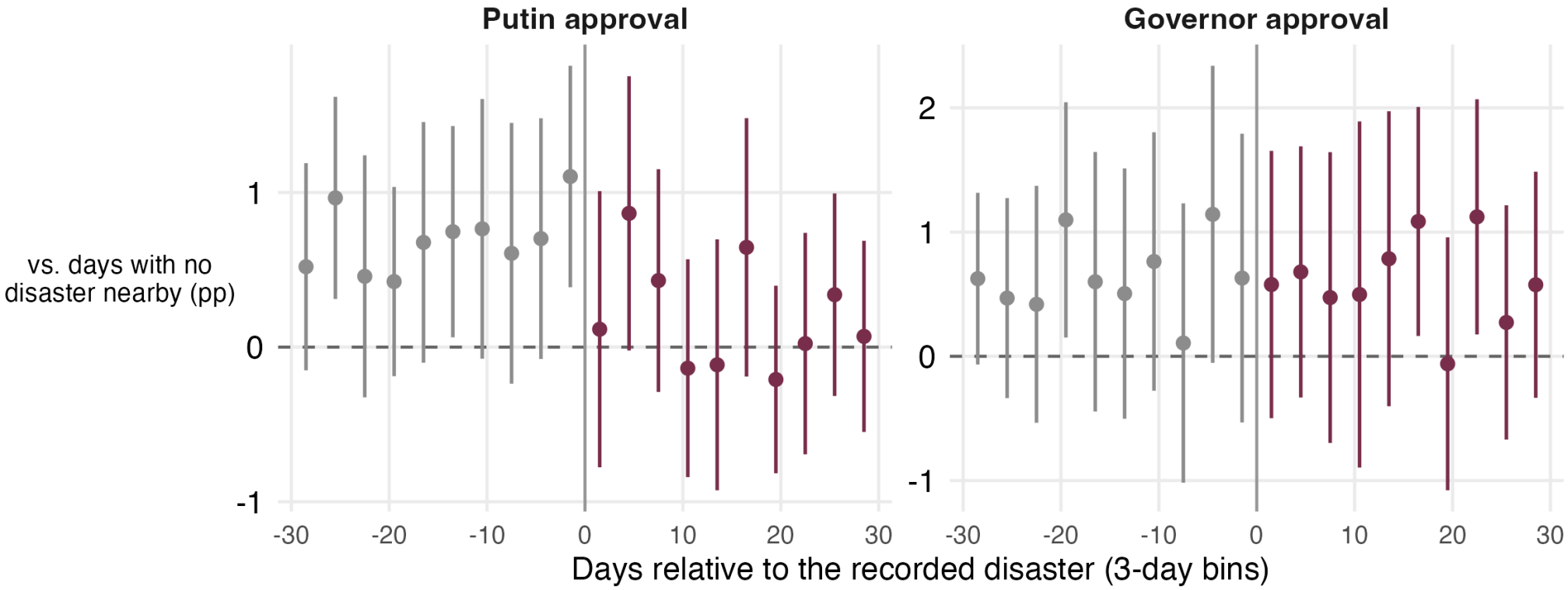
Daily phone survey (VTsIOM, 2018–2022; 1.3 million interviews, 0.46 million of them within a month of 817 dated disasters)

- Putin approval vs. comparable days with no disaster nearby: **+0.8 points in the two weeks before** a recorded disaster, **+0.2 in the month after** (not different from normal days)
- Before-to-after: –0.6 points (SE 0.2): the “before” bump receding, not a drop below normal. Governor: no change
- One specification; region-specific 2022 shocks not yet excluded

Stricter comparison (each deadly disaster vs. regions with no disaster within two months)

- Keeps 19 of 78 events (16 regions): Putin –0.4 (SE 0.5), governor –0.2 (SE 1.5)
- Too few events: can only detect effects above ~1.4 points (Putin), ~4 (governor)

Day by day, in the daily phone survey



- VTsIOM daily survey, 2018–2022: 1.3 million interviews, 0.46 million of them within a month of 817 dated disasters
- Putin: higher in the weeks **before**; nothing special **after**. Governor: up on both sides
- Interview day is imputed (±1–2 days); one specification; 2022 shocks not yet excluded

Other news as a placebo; who notices

Swap disasters for other regional news (same digests, same model)

- Positive economic news: nothing before (+0.0) or after (–0.1)
- Positive *ceremonial* news (sports openings, honours, festivals): **+0.5 before**, +0.2 after
- A "before" bump this size is not unique to disasters; it does not say what causes either. Ceremonial items are scheduled in advance

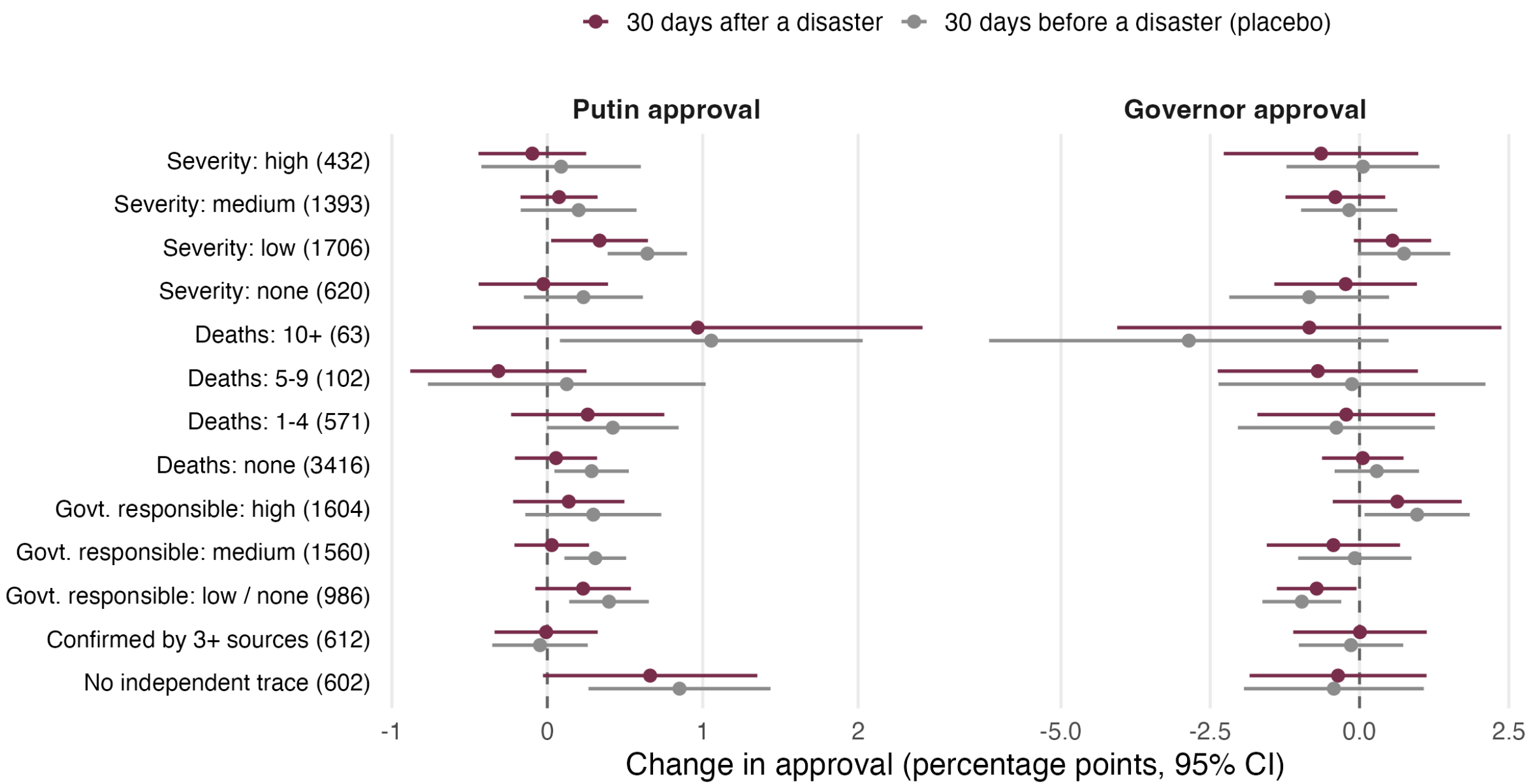
Who notices? ("which events of the past week do you remember?", VTsIOM 2012–17)

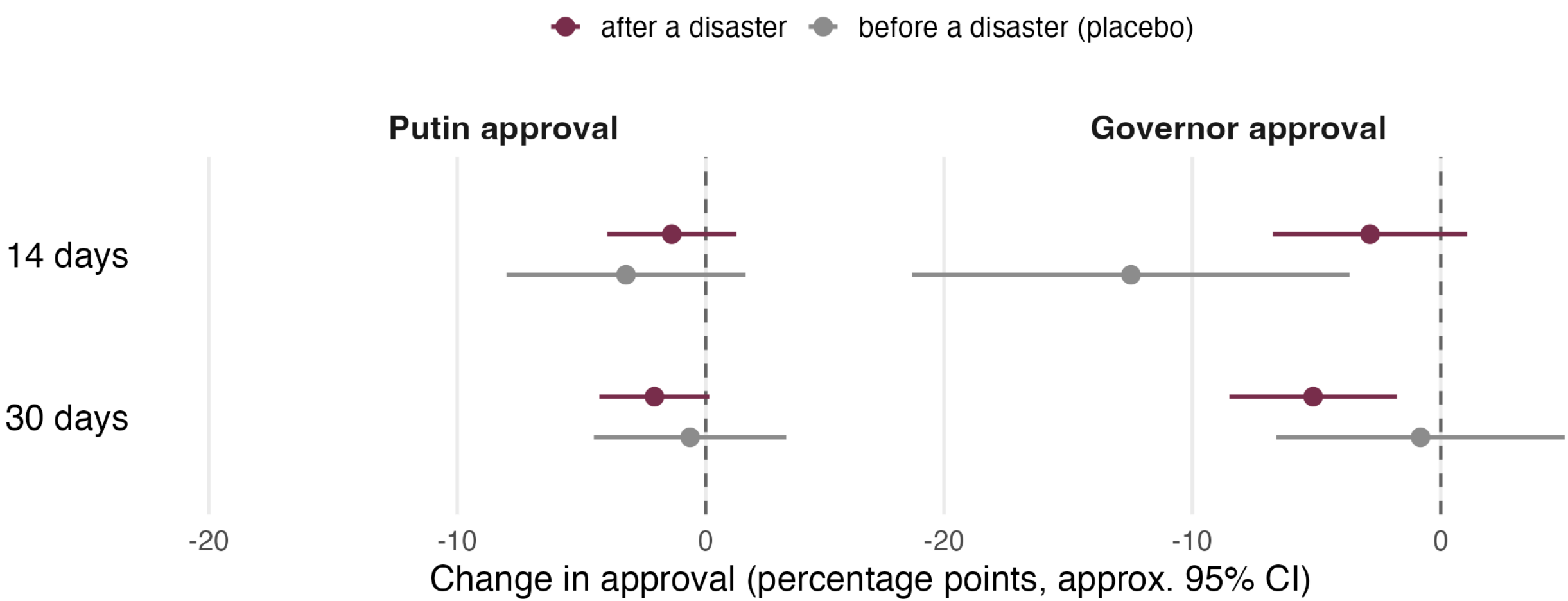
- Typical disaster: +0.3 points naming a disaster (5% base; not significant)
- 5+ deaths: +3.7 in the first week; high severity +2.7; about half that by a month

Do positive and negative reactions cancel out?

- **Across regions:** for Putin, no more significant regions than chance; the spread is noise
- **Across people:** by prior regional support, age, education, internet use, town size: every group within half a point for Putin except low education (+0.8, small subsample, p = .06) (governors: +2 where they were least popular, ~0 elsewhere)
- **Across disasters:** each of the biggest disasters sits inside its own placebo range
- **Across eras:** a small rally before 2014, no clear effect after

- Can't see: opposite reactions among similar people in the same place. A yes/no question only shows the average
- Next: do disaster-by-disaster effects spread more than placebo "disasters" do?


30 days after a disaster
30 days before a disaster (placebo)
Putin approval
Governor approval
Severity: high (432)
Severity: medium (1393)
Severity: low (1706)
Severity: none (620)
Deaths: 10+ (63)
Deaths: 5-9 (102)
Deaths: 1-4 (571)
Deaths: none (3416)
Govt. responsible: high (1604)
Govt. responsible: medium (1560)
Govt. responsible: low / none (986)
Confirmed by 3+ sources (612)
No independent trace (602)
-1
0
1
2
-5.0
-2.5
0.0
2.5
Change in approval (percentage points, 95% CI)



- Governor –5 points at 30 days with a clean placebo, but a **–12-point "before"** at 14 days
- 80 of the 83 "first" disasters fall in the first months of the data (2012–13): mostly a start-of-sample effect

Who might react more?

group (30 days)	**Putin**	**governor**
internet users	+0.16 (0.12)	+0.13 (0.35)
not online	+0.08 (0.11)	+0.10 (0.32)
urban	+0.07 (0.12)	+0.26 (0.33)
rural	+0.34 (0.17)	−0.19 (0.39)

Percentage points, after a disaster; no placebo column in this run (Oct 1 build).

More detail

- Full technical backup (threats to the null, dating tiers, onset tables, inference, multiplicity): the v2 deck, `slides_2026-10-17_v2.html`